The teaching profession under pressure

Global challenges and the case of England

Dr Wonyong Park | EDUC1033 Week 9



Dobrislava, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Session outline

1. What would count as a crisis in teacher supply?
2. International evidence on teachers' work
3. England: recruitment, retention, workload and pay
4. Policy responses and a summary of the evidence

ACTIVITY 1 · IN PAIRS, 3 MINUTES

Name one reason someone might want to become a teacher.

Name one condition that would help them stay in teaching for ten years.

Are your two answers about the same thing?

Keep your answers: we come back to them at the end.

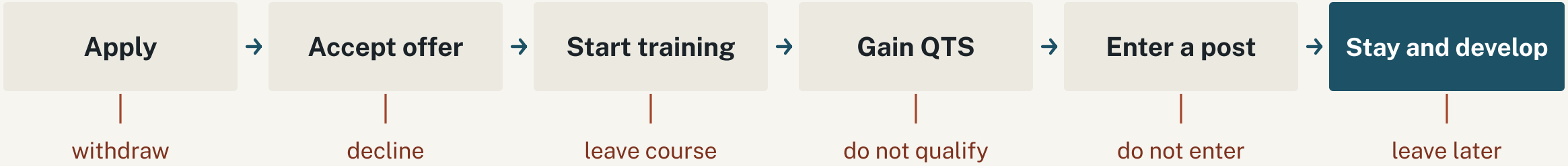
What would count as a crisis in teacher supply?

"Crisis" suggests a serious problem that existing arrangements are failing to manage. In discussions of teaching, the word can refer to several connected but different problems.

Recruitment	Too few people apply to train, start training or enter teaching posts.
Retention	Too many teachers leave a school, the state-funded sector or the occupation.
Matching	Teachers are not available in particular subjects or places, such as physics or some regions.
Working conditions	Teachers in post find the work difficult to sustain.

An education system can improve on one of these measures while continuing to struggle on another.

Teacher supply works like a pipeline



Targets describe flow

A training target concerns the expected flow of future teachers, not the number already in schools. Returners and teachers from other sectors also add to supply.

Where "leaving" is drawn

Moving school leaves an employer, not the system. Moving to an independent school leaves the state-funded sector but not teaching. A career break may end in return.

Totals and specialisms

Extra trainees in one subject cannot fill vacancies in another. Schools may use non-specialists or temporary staff, which vacancy counts do not fully show.

Long & Bridges (2026), section 2; Worth & Scott (2026), pp. 10–17; report section 1.

Key terms used in the evidence

Recruitment	Bringing people into training or teaching posts
Retention	Remaining in a specified school, sector or occupation
Attrition	Leaving the population that a study follows
Shortage	A gap between the teachers needed and those available
FTE	Full-time equivalent: two half-time teachers equal one FTE
Cohort	A group followed from a shared starting point, such as the year of qualifying
Percentage point	20% to 25% is a rise of 5 percentage points, or a 25% proportional increase

Four questions to ask of any statistic

- **Population:** who exactly is counted?
- **Question:** what was asked or measured?
- **Comparison:** compared with what, and when?
- **Uncertainty:** sample size, response bias, or a forecast?

It also helps to check whether a result describes a **level** at one time, a **change** over time, or a **relationship** between two variables.

Report, "Key terms" and section 4.

International evidence on teachers' work

UNESCO's estimate of global teacher need, and the OECD's TALIS 2024 survey of teachers' working lives.



A classroom in Japan · Darklanlan, Wikimedia Commons, CC0

UNESCO estimates that 44 million more teachers are needed by 2030

The estimate covers the additional primary and secondary teachers needed to achieve universal education at these levels. Around 15 million of them are in sub-Saharan Africa.



Additional teachers needed by 2030, total 44 million

Expansion

More children need places in school, or the pupil population is growing. This need exists even if every teacher stays.

Replacement

Teachers retire, change occupation or leave. A system with falling pupil numbers can still face shortages if departures are high.

Distribution

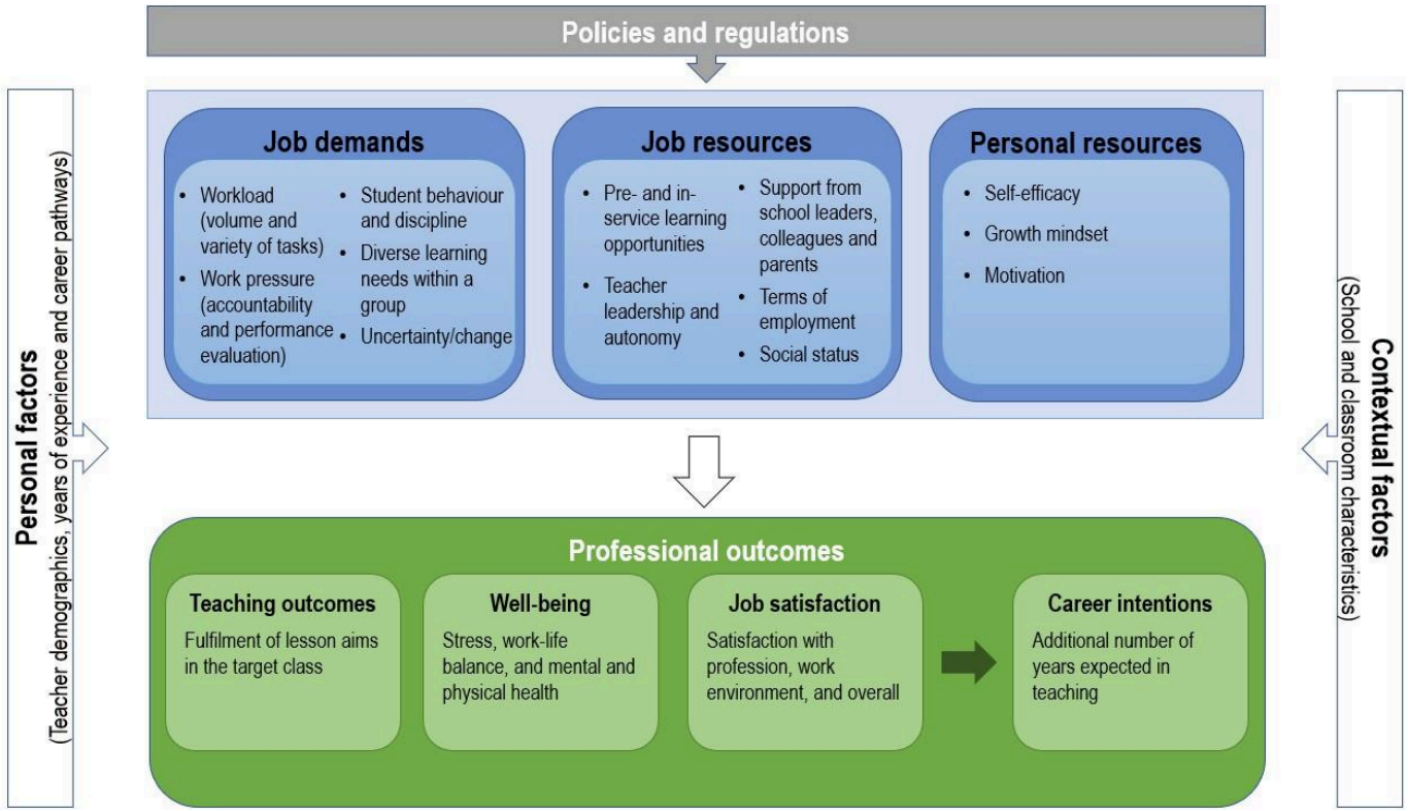
International recruitment moves teachers between systems. Its effects depend on conditions in both the sending and receiving countries.

This is a **projection of future need**, not a count of current vacancies.

UNESCO & International Task Force on Teachers for Education 2030 (2024), *Global report on teachers*.

The OECD links job demands and resources to teachers' outcomes

Figure 1. Conceptual model for TALIS 2024 initial report



Job demands require sustained effort: workload, accountability, pupil behaviour, diverse learning needs and change.

Job resources help teachers meet those demands: professional learning, support from leaders and colleagues, autonomy and terms of employment.

The model connects these to **wellbeing, satisfaction and career intentions**, including how long teachers expect to stay.

The OECD presents this as a **conceptual framework**. The arrows show expected relationships, not measured causal effects.

OECD (2025), *Results from TALIS 2024*, Figure 1, p. 24, after Bakker & Demerouti (2017) and Granziera et al. (2020). © OECD, CC BY 4.0.

TALIS 2024: what the survey covers

The OECD's Teaching and Learning International Survey asks teachers and school leaders about their work. Its main comparisons are of **lower secondary** teachers. Results were published in 2025.

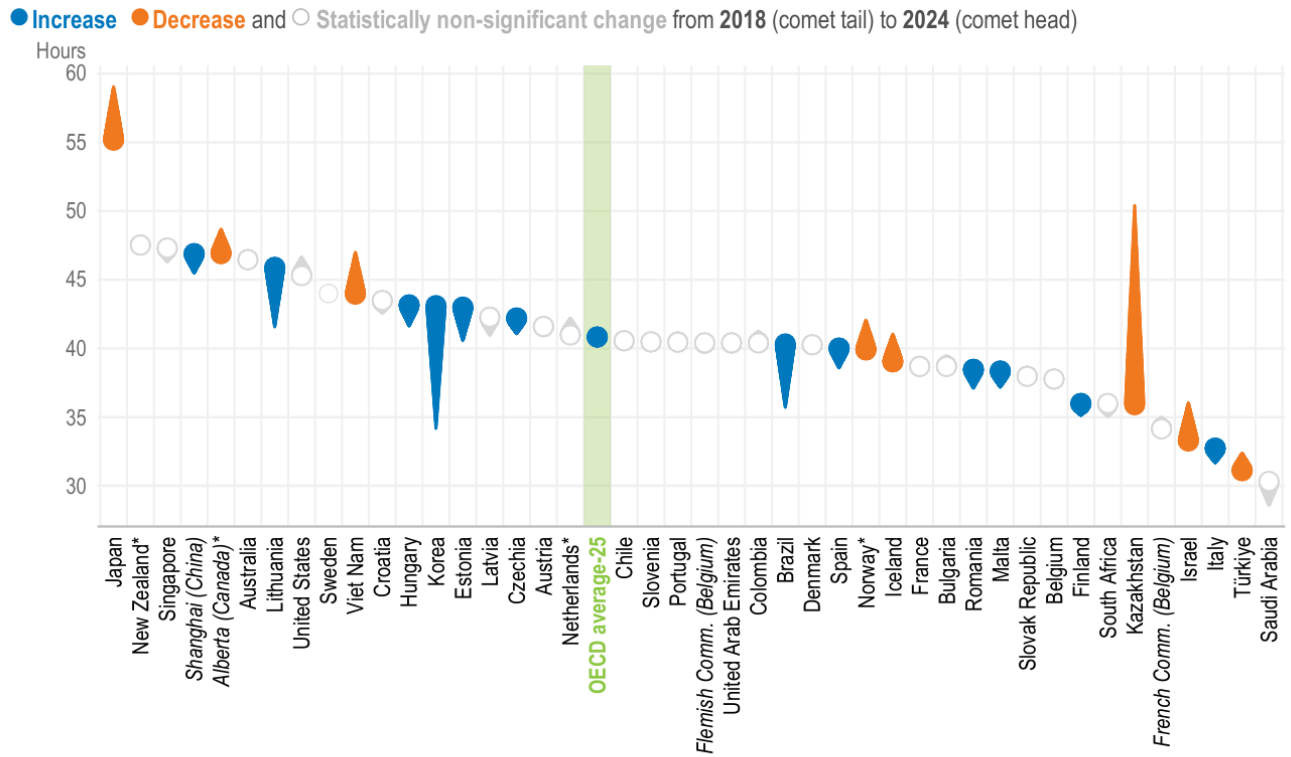
Self-report	Responses describe teachers' reported experiences, such as support, workload and stress. They are not direct observations of classrooms or working hours.
OECD average	The arithmetic average of participating OECD systems with data. It is not weighted by the number of teachers, and the set of systems can differ between indicators.
Association	The survey shows relationships between variables. The OECD states that its design does not establish causal relationships.
England	England took part in TALIS 2018 but **not in TALIS 2024**. Evidence on England in this session comes from DfE statistics, the Working Lives survey and NFER.

OECD (2025), Reader's Guide; OECD TALIS participation lists.

Reported working hours differ widely between systems

Figure 3.2. Change in teachers' total working hours, from 2018 to 2024

Average number of hours full-time lower secondary teachers report spending on job-related tasks during the most recent complete calendar week



Note: *Estimates should be interpreted with caution due to higher risk of non-response bias.
Source: OECD, *TALIS 2018* and *TALIS 2024 Databases*, Table 3.8.

~55 h — **Japan** reports the highest weekly hours, after a statistically significant fall since 2018.

~41 h — The **OECD average-25** (read from the chart).

43% — Share of reported task time spent on **classroom teaching**, OECD average.

Changes since 2018 go in both directions: hours rose in Korea, Lithuania and Brazil, and fell in Japan and Kazakhstan.

OECD (2025), Figure 3.2, p. 108; pp. 108–109. Full-time lower secondary teachers, TALIS 2018 and 2024. © OECD, CC BY 4.0.

Most teachers report job satisfaction, and some report high stress

~9 in 10 lower secondary teachers are **satisfied with their job** (OECD average)

19% experience **stress at work "a lot"**

These come from separate questions and may include the same teachers. They are not two opposing groups.

A teacher can value working with pupils and the purpose of teaching while finding workload, pay, leadership or accountability difficult.

TALIS asks about several aspects of wellbeing: stress, time for personal life, and effects on mental and physical health. These are self-reports, not clinical measures, and differences between countries may partly reflect how people report.

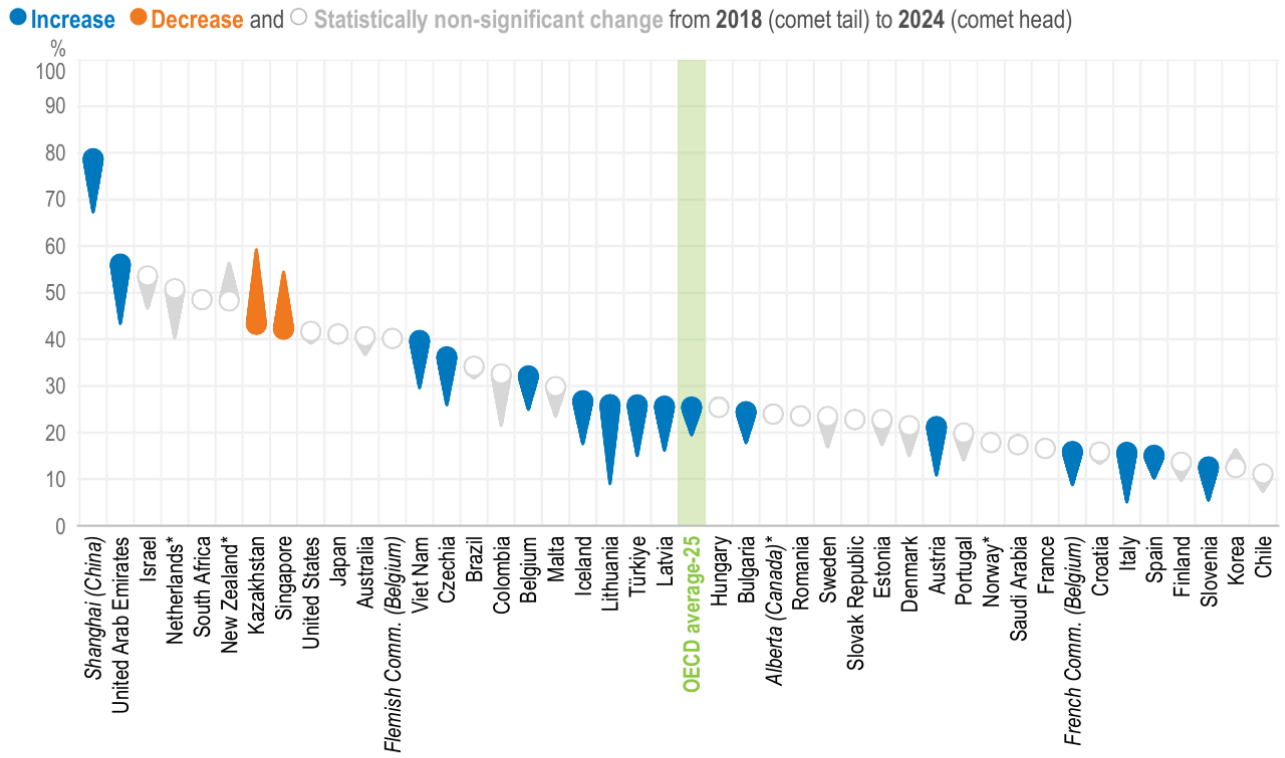
Interviews with teachers in England who had left or were considering leaving also describe valued relationships with pupils alongside pressures of the job.

OECD (2025), pp. 73–76; IFF Research & UCL IOE (2026).

About one in four novice teachers has an assigned mentor

Figure 4.5. Change in novice teachers' access to mentoring, from 2018 to 2024

Percentage of novice lower secondary teachers who have an assigned mentor



Note: * Estimates should be interpreted with caution due to higher risk of non-response bias.
Novice teachers refer to those with up to five years of teaching experience.
Source: OECD, *TALIS 2018 and TALIS 2024 Databases*, Table 4.11.

~25% of **novice teachers** (up to five years' experience) have an assigned mentor, OECD average

~79% in **Shanghai (China)**, the highest share

+17 pp increase in **Lithuania** since 2018

55% say professional learning had a positive impact on their teaching "quite a bit" or "a lot"

The question asks about a *current* mentor, so mentoring received earlier is not captured.

OECD (2025), Figure 4.5, p. 147; p. 137. © OECD, CC BY 4.0.

Three international examples in the TALIS data

Japan

country

Reported hours fell between 2018 and 2024 but remain the highest in TALIS. A before-and-after comparison does not show which measures produced the change.

Shanghai

subnational system

Assigned mentoring is far more common than the OECD average. The label "mentor" can cover arrangements from scheduled meetings to sustained classroom guidance.

Lithuania

country

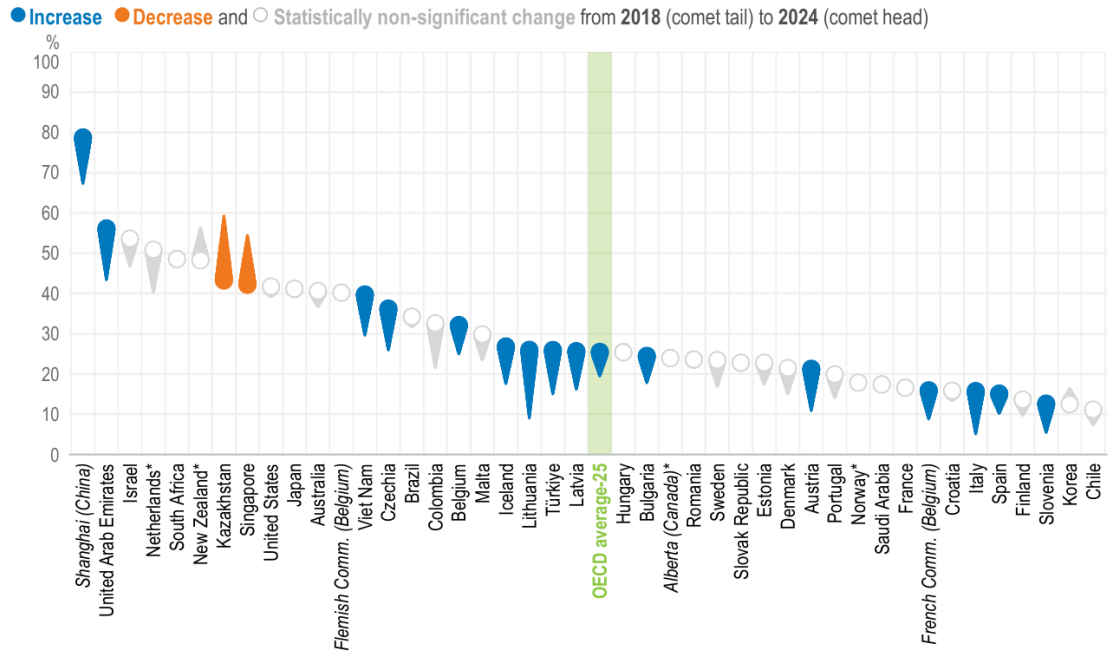
Access to mentoring rose substantially. The report notes questions about mentor time, mentor preparation, and whether support reached schools with staffing difficulties.

Shanghai is a **subnational system**, not China as a whole. TALIS "novice teachers" (up to five years) are a different group from England's two-year **early career teacher** category.

OECD (2025), pp. 29, 108, 147; report section 8.

Figure 4.5. Change in novice teachers' access to mentoring, from 2018 to 2024

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Note: * Estimates should be interpreted with caution due to higher risk of non-response bias.
Novice teachers refer to those with up to five years of teaching experience.
Source: OECD, *TALIS 2018 and TALIS 2024 Databases*, Table 4.11.

ACTIVITY 2 · IN PAIRS, 5 MINUTES

Read the mentoring chart using the four questions.

- Who is in the chart?
- What were teachers asked?
- What is compared, and when?
- What do the asterisks and grey markers mean?

What else would you need to know before using Shanghai as a model for England?

England: recruitment, retention, workload and pay

DfE statistics, NFER's annual labour market report, and the Working Lives of Teachers and Leaders survey.



Albany Senior School, Enfield, 1943 · Ministry of Information, public domain

How England's system is organised

England, not the UK

Education is devolved. England, Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland differ on qualifications, training routes and early career support.

State-funded schools include maintained schools and academies. Independent schools and further education colleges are counted differently.

QTS and the PGCE

Qualified teacher status is a professional status for meeting the Teachers' Standards. A **PGCE** is an academic award.

An undergraduate Education degree does not automatically award QTS.

Headcount and FTE

Headcount counts people; FTE counts full-time posts. A teacher moving to part-time work reduces FTE without leaving.

Primary pupil numbers are falling, while secondary and special schools follow different patterns.

Two reports can appear to disagree when they cover **different populations, units or dates**.

Long & Bridges (2026); DfE, *Get Into Teaching*; Worth & Scott (2026), pp. 4, 8–10.

Routes into teaching in England

ROUTE	IN BRIEF
Undergraduate ITT	A degree combined with professional preparation and QTS
Teacher degree apprenticeship	An employed route with degree-level training
Postgraduate, fee-funded	For graduates; often QTS with a PGCE
Postgraduate, salaried	Training while employed by a school
Assessment-only	For experienced teachers without QTS
Overseas-trained	Recognition routes, subject to criteria

Partnership

Schools provide practice and mentoring. Universities contribute research, subject knowledge, educational study and academic awards. Many routes involve both.

After QTS

Early career teachers (ECTs) receive a two-year induction. The Early Career Teacher Entitlement, introduced from September 2025, links to the ITT and Early Career Framework.

Fees, salary, personal circumstances and placement location affect which route is possible for an applicant.

Long & Bridges (2026), sections 2.1 and 3.2; DfE, *Get Into Teaching*.

A critical perspective on teacher education

In *Teacher Education in Crisis*, Ellis and Childs (2024) argue that reforms in England intensified central control over training providers and constrained the contribution of universities.

Their account is informed by the experiences of teacher educators. The report presents it as one scholarly interpretation, to be read alongside the stated aims of policy documents.

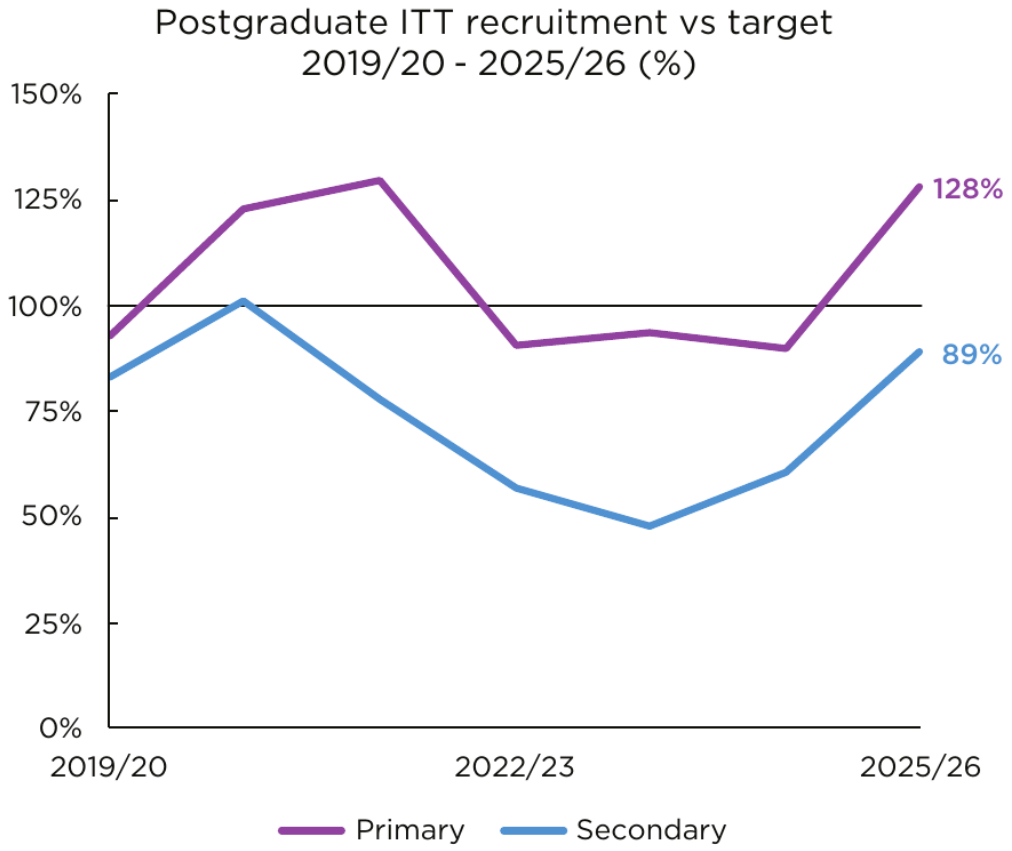
It connects teacher supply to a wider question: how practical competence, knowledge of subjects and pupils, and professional judgement fit together in teacher preparation, and who decides.



Fortepan 3612, Wikimedia Commons, public domain

Ellis & Childs (2024), "Introducing the crisis", in V. Ellis (Ed.), *Teacher Education in Crisis*, pp. 1–26.

Recruitment to postgraduate training rose in 2025/26



Source: DfE ITT Census.

128% — **Primary** recruitment as a share of target, 2025/26

89% — **Secondary** recruitment as a share of target, 2025/26

<50% — Secondary in 2023/24, the lowest point in the period (read from the chart)

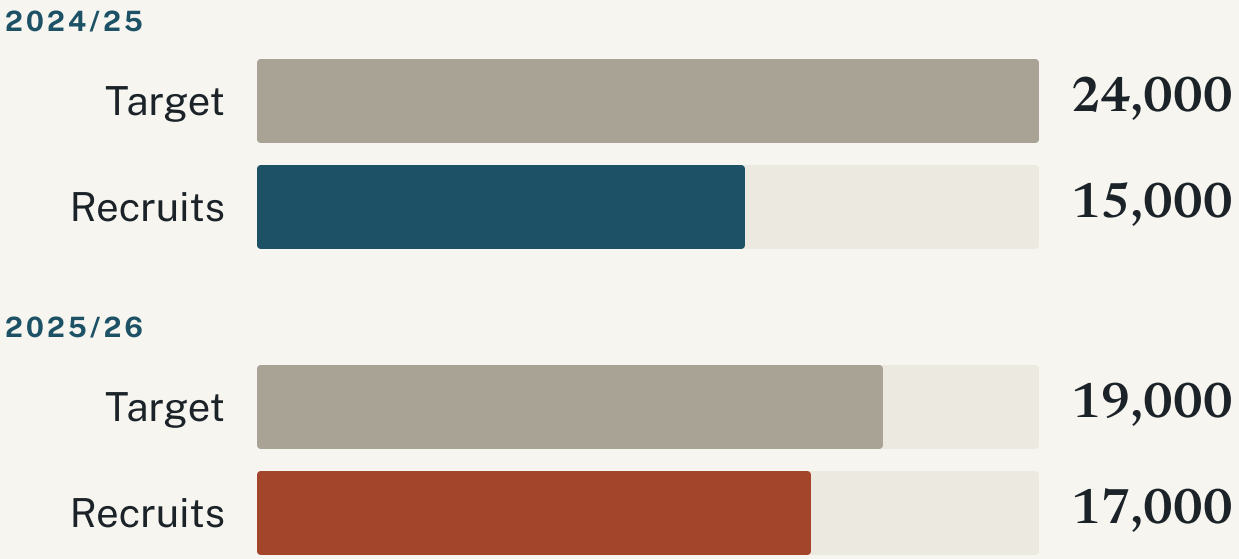
NFER links the improvement partly to weaker job opportunities for graduates elsewhere.

These are NFER's March 2026 figures. The February 2026 Commons briefing reports different percentages, so the two sources should not be combined.

Worth & Scott (2026), NFER, p. 10, using DfE ITT Census data.

Both the number of recruits and the target changed

Secondary postgraduate ITT, rounded figures



Targets: "nearly 24,000" and "a little over 19,000". Recruits: "around 15,000" and "around 17,000".

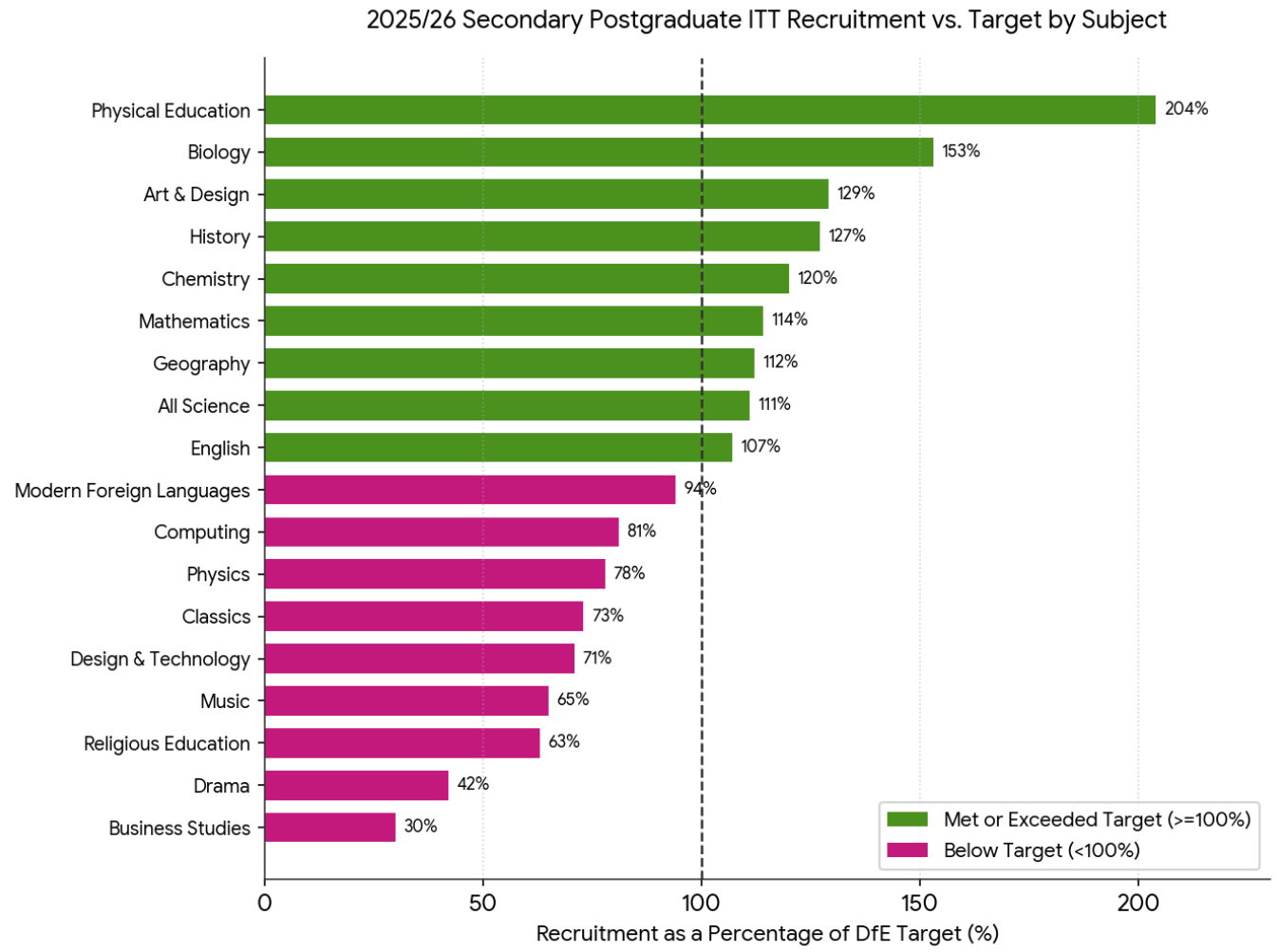
Recruits rose by about **2,000**. The target fell by about **5,000**. Both changes raised the percentage of target met.

A target is an estimate of future need. It rests on assumptions about pupil numbers, retention, returners and other sources of teachers.

The percentage of target met cannot, on its own, show how much of the change came from more entrants and how much from a lower estimated requirement.

Worth & Scott (2026), p. 10; report section 11.

Recruitment against target varies widely by subject



Source: NFER analysis of DfE Initial Teacher Training (ITT) Census (2025/26).

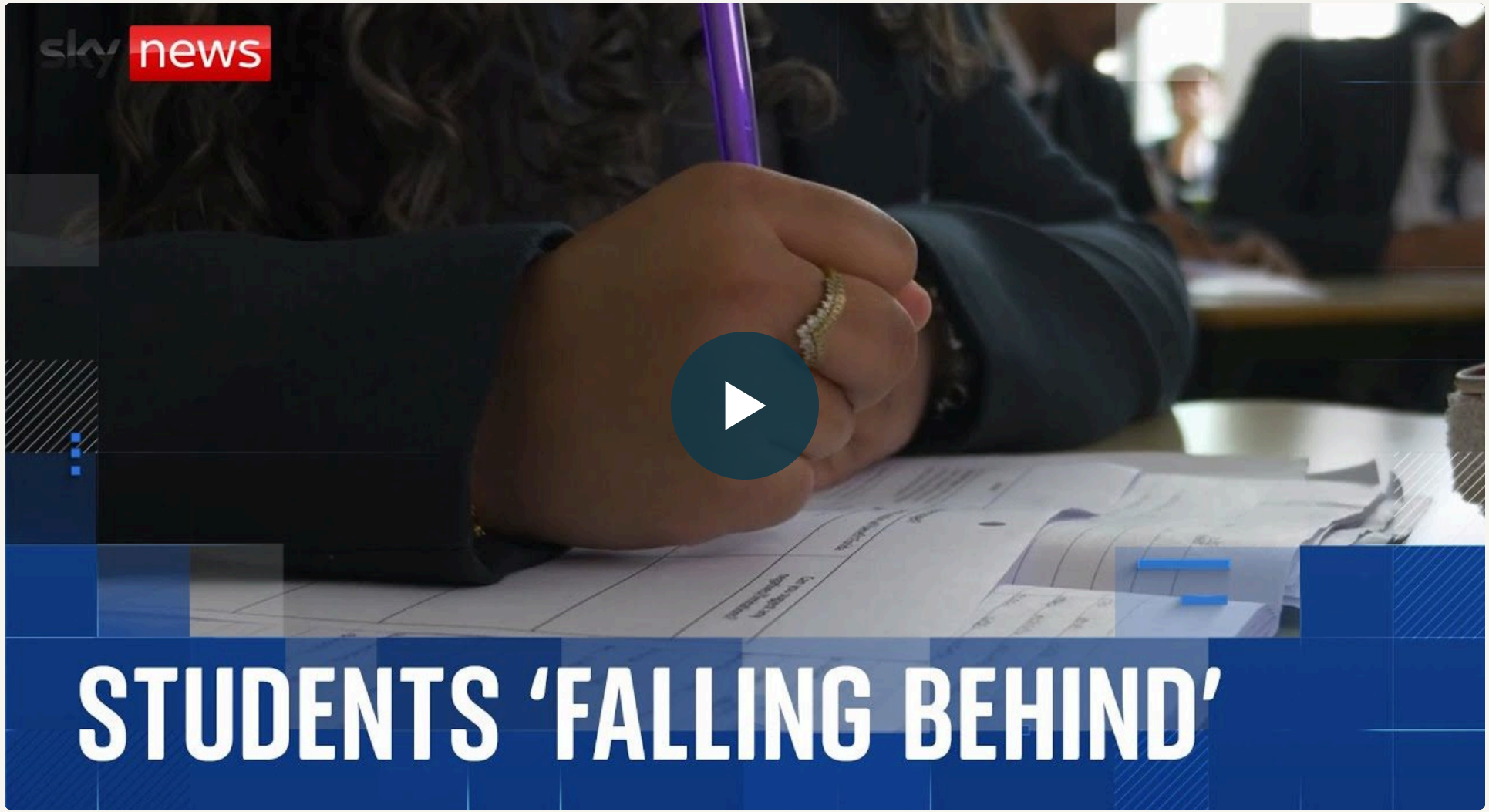
Nine of eighteen secondary subjects were below target in 2025/26.

SUBJECT	% OF TARGET
Business studies	30%
Music	65%
Physics	78%
Computing	81%
Mathematics	114%
Physical education	204%

Each subject has its own target. 204% means 104% above target, not a rise on the previous year.

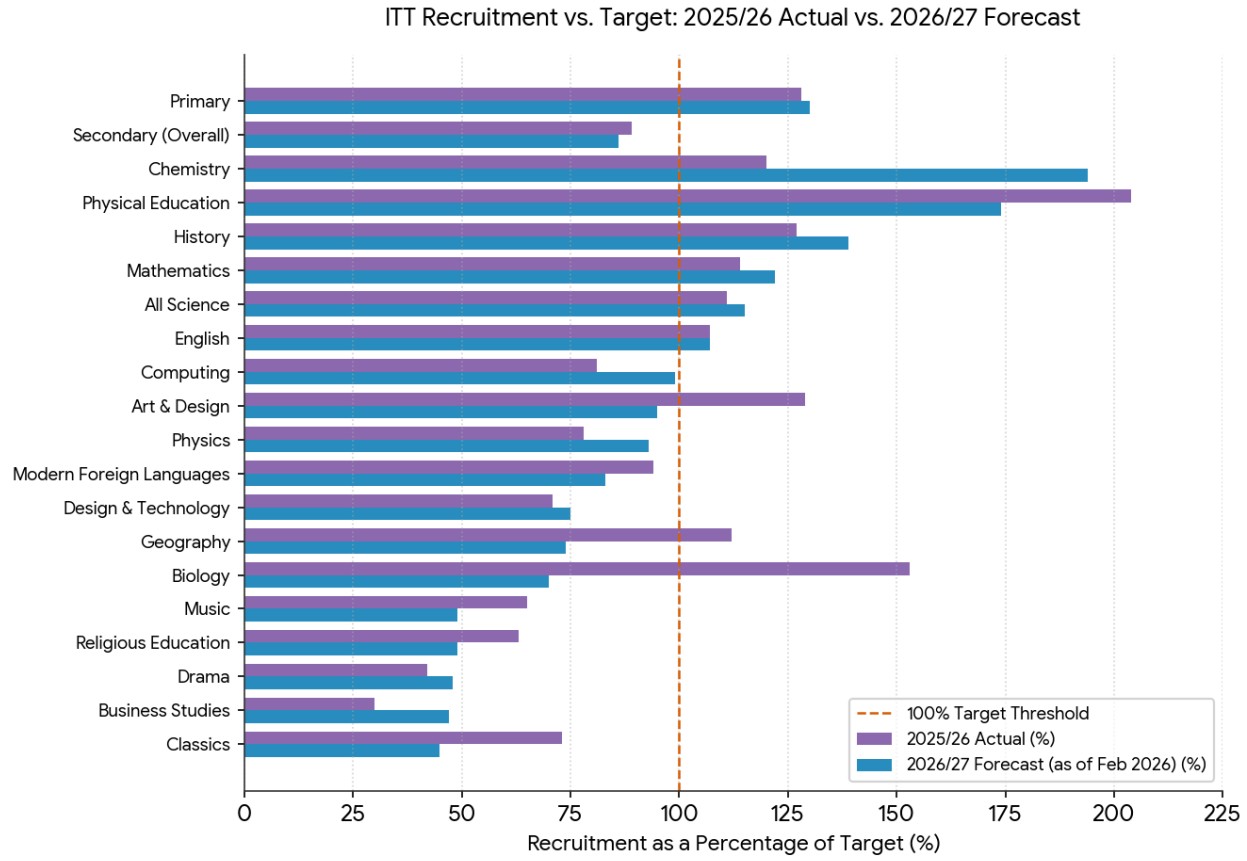
NFER analysis of DfE ITT Census 2025/26; Worth & Scott (2026), p. 11.

Students' accounts of teacher shortages



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wxp2Sj6gl50 · Sky News, *Students say they are 'falling behind' due to chronic teacher shortages*

NFER's forecast for 2026/27 shows changes by subject



Source: NFER analysis of DfE ITT Census and Apply data up to February 2026.

SUBJECT	2025/26	2026/27 FORECAST
Secondary overall	89%	~86%
Physics	78%	~93%
Computing	81%	~99%
Biology	153%	~70%
Geography	112%	~74%
Music	65%	~49%

Forecasts use application data up to February 2026 and are not outcomes. Forecast values are read from the chart.

NFER analysis of DfE ITT Census and Apply data to February 2026 (Worth & Scott, 2026).

About two in three teachers from the 2020 cohort remained after five years

89.7% of teachers who **qualified in 2024** were in England's state-funded schools **one year later**

67.4% of the **2020 cohort** were there **five years after** qualifying

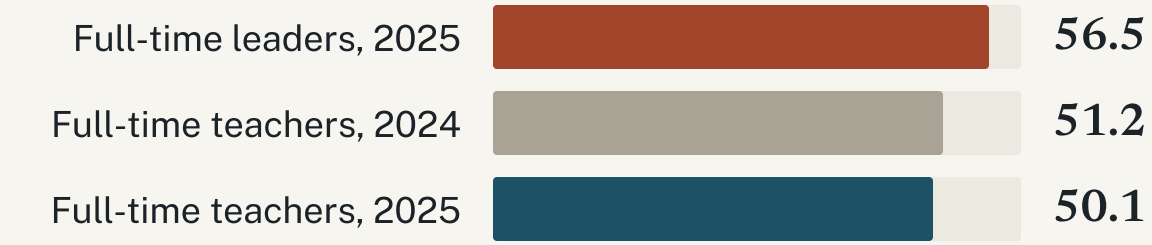
These are different cohorts. They should not be read as one group falling from 89.7% to 67.4%. The DfE notes that the pandemic complicates comparisons between periods.

- **Cohort retention and annual exit rates** answer different questions. One describes how much of a starting group remains; the other describes departures in a single year.
- **Leaving the measured sector is not the same as leaving teaching.** Teachers may move to another UK nation, an independent school, another education role or a career break, and some return.
- **Experience carries knowledge** of subjects, pupils and school routines. The report notes that departures can also affect colleagues who take on mentoring or extra classes.

DfE (2026a), *School workforce in England: reporting year 2025* (June 2026); Long & Bridges (2026), section 2.4.

Reported hours have fallen slightly, and more teachers find workload acceptable

Hours in the most recent full term-time week



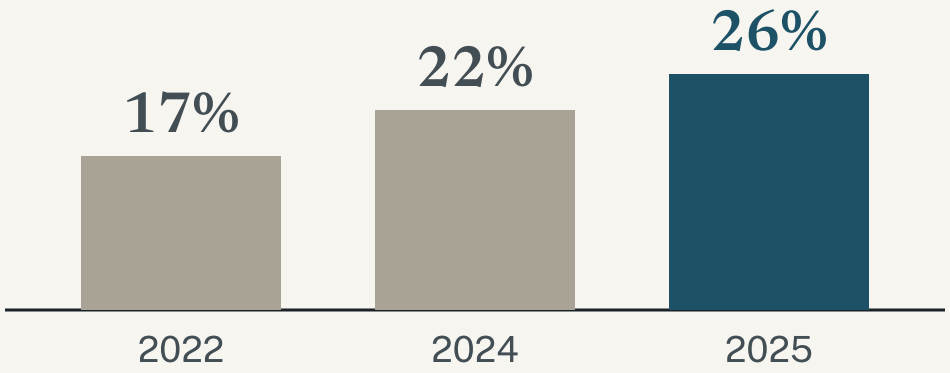
Working Lives survey, Wave 4, January–May 2025; 10,808 teachers and leaders

Labour Force Survey estimate, 2024/25



Lower estimates than the Working Lives survey, with a similar recent downward trend

"My workload is acceptable": teachers and leaders



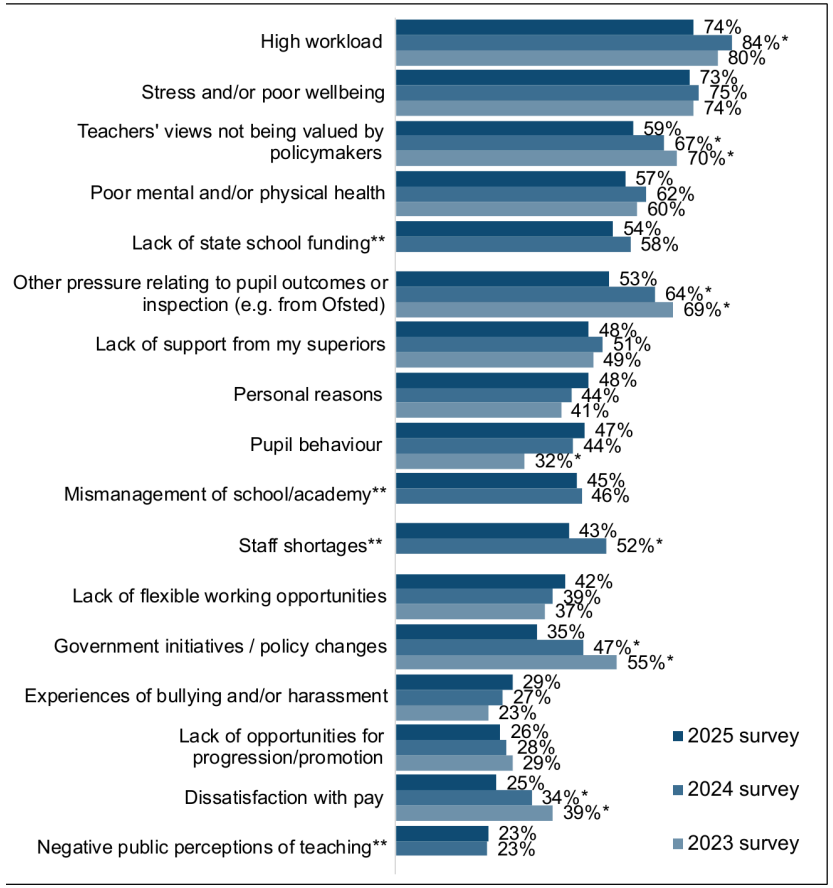
About three in four teachers and leaders did not agree that their workload was acceptable in 2025.

The 26% covers teachers and leaders together; the 50.1 hours covers full-time teachers only.

IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025), *Working lives of teachers and leaders: Wave 4*, pp. 6–8; Worth & Scott (2026), p. 20.

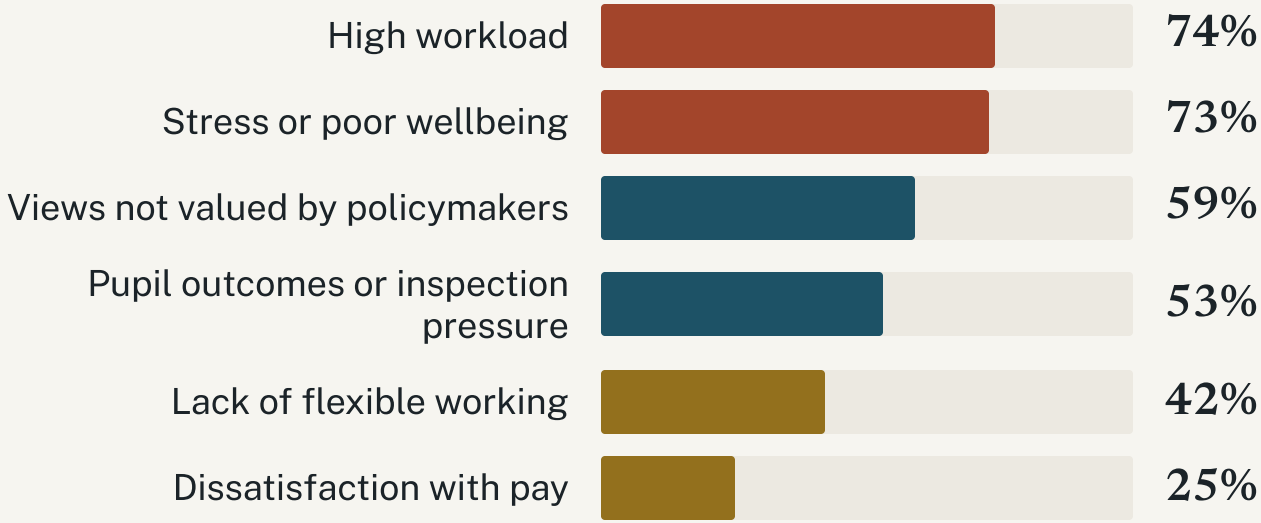
Leavers most often cite workload and stress

Figure 11.1 Proportion of leavers citing different reasons for leaving the English state school education sector



Source: Working lives of teachers and leaders survey. M6. How important were the following factors in your decision to leave the state education sector? Single response. All who have left the state education sector (wave 2, 2023, n=442) (wave 3, 2024, n=520) (wave 4, 2025, n=461). *Indicates significant difference compared to 2025 survey. **Indicates response option not asked in 2023 survey.

2025 leavers (n = 461) rating each factor important

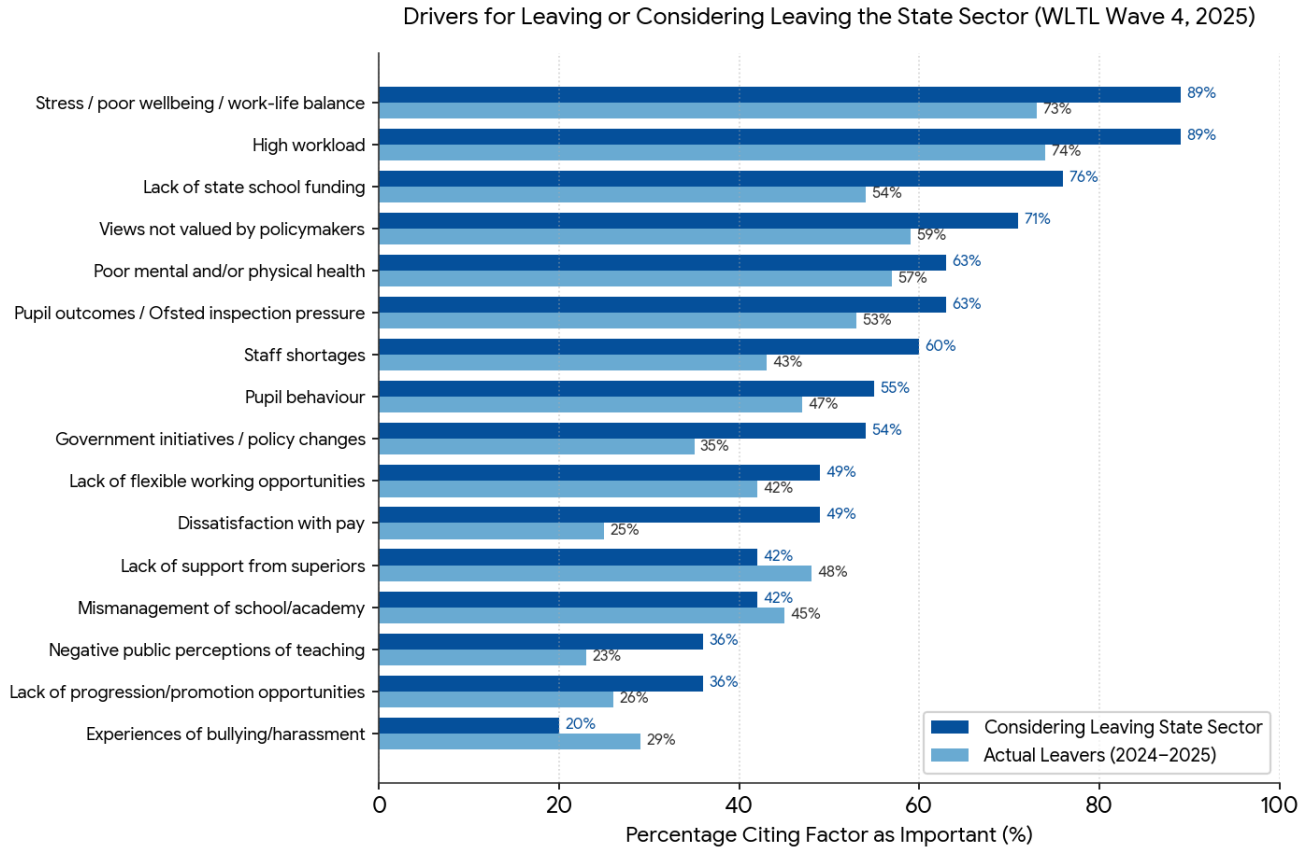


Since 2023, fewer leavers cite inspection pressure (69% to 53%), government initiatives (55% to 35%) and pay (39% to 25%).

Each factor was rated separately, so percentages overlap and should not be added. The leaver group includes retirees.

IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025), Figure 11.1, p. 36; pp. 35–36. Crown copyright, Open Government Licence v3.0.

Teachers considering leaving cite many of the same factors



Source: DfE Working Lives of Teachers and Leaders (WLTL) Wave 4 Survey (2025).

FACTOR	CONSIDERING	LEFT
Stress, wellbeing	89%	73%
High workload	89%	74%
School funding	76%	54%
Staff shortages	60%	43%
Pay	49%	25%

Leavers more often cite lack of support from superiors (48% vs 42%) and bullying (29% vs 20%). The two groups differ: one is still in post, the other has left and includes retirees.

DfE Working Lives of Teachers and Leaders (WLTL) Wave 4 survey (2025).

A teacher's account of workload



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jNUZKdQ1PEQ · BBC Teach, *Confessions of a Teacher: Workload*

Recurring themes in interviews with leavers

- Enjoyment of classroom teaching and relationships with pupils
- Administrative demands and limited support
- Difficulty keeping boundaries around work
- Less autonomy, and a gap between what teachers valued and how the job had developed

60 interviews in autumn 2025 with teachers and leaders who had left or were considering leaving.

IFF Research & UCL IOE (2026), *Qualitative insight into experiences of leavers and those considering leaving*, pp. 5–7. Crown copyright, OGL v3.0.

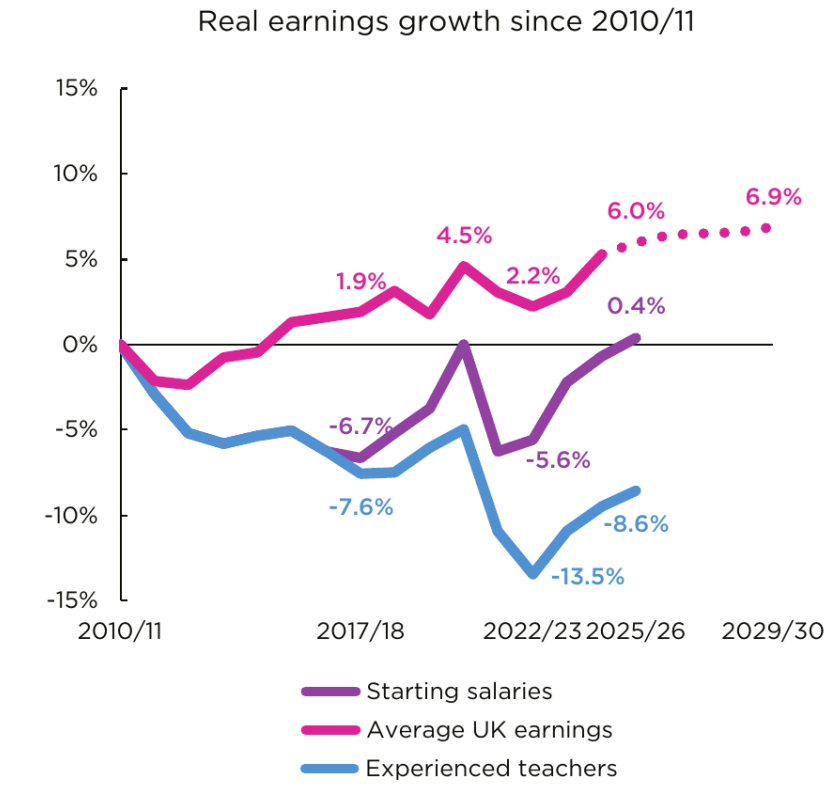
ACTIVITY 3 · IN SMALL GROUPS, 6 MINUTES

What did the teacher in the video describe about their workload?

Which parts of their account match the survey and interview evidence we have seen?

What can one personal account tell us, and what can it not tell us?

Starting salaries have returned to their 2010/11 real level; experienced teachers' pay has not



Note: 'Experienced teachers' refers to teachers at the top of the upper pay scale. The dotted line represents the forecast of real earnings growth based on OBR projections from March 2026.

Sources: School Teachers' Pay and Conditions Document; Office for Budget Responsibility.

+0.4%	**Starting salaries**, real terms, 2025/26 vs 2010/11
−8.6%	**Experienced teachers** (top of the upper pay scale), after a low of −13.5% in 2022/23
+6.0%	**Average UK earnings** over the same period

Real pay adjusts for prices. **Relative pay** compares teaching with other jobs open to graduates. The dotted line is an OBR projection from March 2026.

Worth & Scott (2026), p. 18. Sources: School Teachers' Pay and Conditions Document; Office for Budget Responsibility.

Policy responses

The Department for Education's 6,500 additional teachers delivery plan, and a summary of the evidence.



Julian Herzog, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 4.0

The pledge of 6,500 additional teachers

Additional FTE against the 2023/24 baseline, DfE 2025 workforce release

4,654 of 6,500



What is counted	A **net increase in FTE** compared with 2023/24, by the end of this Parliament.
Which settings	Mainstream secondary schools, special schools and further education colleges. **Primary schools are not included** in this count.
What affects it	New entrants, departures and changes in working hours all change net FTE, so recruiting 6,500 trainees would not by itself meet the pledge.
Reading the update	The 4,654 figure is an intermediate observation. The report notes that it differs from change across all state-funded school teachers, and that increases can have several causes.

DfE (2026b), *6,500 additional teachers delivery plan*, pp. 4–7; DfE (2026a).

The delivery plan groups action under attract, retain and develop

Attract

Entry into teaching

- Financial incentives for trainees
- Training routes
- Support for applicants and returners

Retain

Staying in teaching

- Pay and workload
- Flexible working, such as part-time roles and some non-teaching tasks off site
- Targeted incentives for subjects or settings

Develop

Growing expertise

- Early career support
- Professional learning
- Routes into specialist and leadership roles

The report notes that effects depend on implementation: whether candidates can access support, whether schools and providers have capacity, and whether mentors and mentees have time.

DfE (2026b), pp. 10–18; report section 18.

ACTIVITY 4 · IN SMALL GROUPS, 8 MINUTES

Choose two of these priorities. For each, explain which problem it addresses and find one piece of evidence from today that relates to it.

- Financial support for entry into training
- Competitive pay
- Protected mentoring and professional learning
- Reduced administration and more flexibility

The options do not cost the same. Note one difficulty in putting each choice into practice.

Summary of the evidence on England

Indicators that have improved

- Postgraduate ITT recruitment: primary 128%, secondary 89% of target in 2025/26
- Full-time teachers' reported hours: 51.2 to 50.1
- Workload rated acceptable: 17% (2022) to 26% (2025)
- Starting salaries back to their 2010/11 real level
- 4,654 additional FTE towards the 6,500 pledge

Pressures that continue

- Subjects below target, e.g. business studies 30%, physics 78%, computing 81%
- 67.4% of the 2020 cohort in state-funded schools after five years
- About three in four do not find workload acceptable
- Experienced teachers' real pay 8.6% below 2010/11
- 74% of leavers cite workload; 73% cite stress

The report describes the evidence as supporting a qualified assessment: the picture differs between subjects, schools and career stages.

Report sections 11–20; sources as on previous slides.

Back to joining and staying

Return to your answers from Activity 1. Write two or three sentences that:

1. connect one reason to join with one condition to stay
2. use one finding from today, naming its population and date
3. say what the evidence can and cannot establish

Further reading

- Worth & Scott (2026), NFER annual report, pp. 10–24
- OECD (2025), TALIS 2024, executive summary, pp. 28–30
- IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025), Working Lives Wave 4, pp. 32–38
- Ellis & Childs (2024), pp. 1–26

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